

NIRVAN SUTRA

Nirvan Sutra

Chapter 5: Neti-Neti

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A COURSE CHAPTER FOR SINCERE SEEKERS

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Chapter 5: Neti-Neti

First Section - The Gentle Direction of “Not This, Not This”

In the previous chapter we saw the layers of ego. Ego is not only pride. It can create identity from body, mind, name, role, image, story, experience, and even spiritual identity. It may say, “I am the body.” It may say, “My thoughts are me.” It may say, “My role is me.” It may say, “My story is me.” It may even say, “I have understood, therefore I am special.”

We also saw that ego is not to be attacked. It is not to be killed by force. It is to be seen in witness-consciousness. Whatever is clearly seen slowly begins to lose its grip. Now this journey becomes deeper. We enter the direction known in Advaita Vedanta as Neti-Neti.

Neti-Neti means - not this, not this. But do not understand it as rejection of life. It is not running away from the world. It is not hatred of the body, suppression of the mind, abandonment of relationships, or denial of emotions. Neti-Neti means clearly recognizing what I am not, so that what I am becomes clear by itself. It is not negation. It is the cleansing of identity.

When the seeker says, “I am not the body,” it does not mean the body is useless. The body is an instrument of life. It needs food, rest, care, and treatment. This path too is being walked through the body. But the body changes. Childhood passed, youth changes, age will come. The body appears in experience and is known. So the seeker gently sees: “The body is my experience, but not my final nature.” This is Neti.

When the seeker says, “I am not the mind,” it does not mean the mind is an enemy. Through the mind language is understood, planning happens, learning happens, and dialogue becomes possible. But the mind also changes.

Thoughts come and go. Emotions rise and settle. Memories and desires change. So the seeker sees: “The mind appears in experience. I can know it. Therefore the mind is not my final nature.” This too is Neti.

Neti-Neti does not cut things away. It places everything in its right place. The body is here, but I am not merely the body. The mind is here, but I am not merely the mind. Emotion is here, but I am not merely emotion. Thought is here, but I am not merely thought. Role is here, but I am not merely role. Story is here, but I am not merely story. As this becomes clear, the seeker becomes lighter.

Many seekers misunderstand Neti-Neti as harsh denial. They think everything must be rejected, the body must be ignored, the mind must be stopped, emotions must be avoided, and the world must be dismissed. This is not the right direction. If someone says “I am not the body” and neglects the body, that is not understanding. If someone says “I am not the mind” and suppresses emotions, that is not understanding. If someone says “all is Maya” and becomes indifferent to another’s suffering, that is incomplete understanding.

Neti-Neti is a loving inquiry into identity. It is like cleaning a cupboard. You look at each object. Some things are useful, some are old, some are no longer needed. You do not fight the objects. You simply know what belongs where. In the same way, place the body as body, the mind as mind, the role as role, the story as story, and the experience as experience. Do not make any of them the final “I.”

A simple test of Neti-Neti is this: whatever changes cannot be my final nature. The body changes, mind changes, emotions change, thoughts change, roles change, image changes, the meaning of story changes, and spiritual experiences also come and go. Therefore none of these can be the final “I.”

Look carefully. While all this changes, something knows the change. The childhood body changed and was known. A state of mind changed and was

known. Sorrow came and went, and it was known. Success came and went, and it was known. A role changed and was known. A story arose and was known. A spiritual experience came and was known. The seeker slowly asks: am I what is known, or am I that which knows it? This question is the heart of Neti-Neti.

Take the example of clothes. You wear one outfit in the morning, another at another time. Clothes keep changing. They are yours, but you are not the clothes. If a person mistakes clothes for self, he changes with each outfit. Good clothes - "I am good." Old clothes - "I am less." We know clothes are external. Yet in life we wear body, mind, role, and image in the same way and call them "I." Neti-Neti gently says: recognize the garments, use them, respect them, but do not take them as your final self.

Take another example. You sit by a river. Leaves float by, wood floats by, flowers float by, sometimes the water is clear, sometimes muddy. If you grasp each floating object and say, "This is me," you will become restless. Thoughts and emotions flow like that river. One thought comes: "I am successful." Another comes: "I am a failure." Another comes: "I need respect." Another comes: "I am spiritual." Neti-Neti says: not this thought, not this emotion, not this story, not this role.

Neti-Neti must be tender. When you say, "I am not the body," do not be angry with the body. The body has supported your journey. When you say, "I am not the mind," do not blame the mind. The mind gave language, questions, and search. When you say, "I am not the role," do not reject the role. Play it with love and responsibility. When you say, "I am not the story," do not insult your life-story. It taught you much. But do not believe that story is your whole truth.

Neti-Neti and witness-consciousness are not separate paths. Witness-consciousness says: see what is arising. Neti-Neti says: whatever is seen is not the final "I." First there is seeing. Then identity becomes light. This is the beginning of the practice.

Practice for Today

Whenever a strong identity arises today, pause. It may be body-identity: “I am tired,” “I am ill.” It may be mind-identity: “I am worried,” “I am angry,” “I am sad.” It may be role-identity: “I should be respected as a parent,” or “I should be seen as a seeker.” It may be a story: “This always happens to me.” In that moment, gently say: “This is an experience. This is being known. This is not my final nature. Neti. Not this too.”

Second Section - Neti Applied to Body, Mind, and Emotions

In the previous section we understood the simple meaning of Neti-Neti. Now it must be brought into experience. A seeker may have heard many times, “I am not the body,” “I am not the mind,” “I am not the emotion.” But when pain arises in the body, worry moves in the mind, or a deep emotion rises, clarity becomes dim. Then the body feels like me, the mind feels like me, and the emotion feels like me.

The body feels closest. As soon as the eyes open, the body appears. Hunger, thirst, tiredness, pain, and comfort are experienced. Through the body we meet the world. Therefore it feels natural to take the body as “I.” When the body is healthy, the mind says, “I am well.” When the body is ill, it says, “I am broken.” When the body looks attractive, ego says, “I am good.” When the body feels weak, ego says, “I am less.”

Now see through Neti-Neti. The body and its states are changing - hunger and fullness, tiredness and energy, illness and health, comfort and pain. What changes constantly cannot be my final nature. This is not meant to deny the

body. If there is pain, treatment is needed. If there is fatigue, rest is needed. If the body is weak, nourishment is needed. The body is an instrument of sadhana and must be respected. Yet even while caring for the body, clarity can remain: “Pain is in the body. Tiredness is in the body. This is being known. I am not merely the body.”

The test becomes deeper when pain or discomfort is present. When the body is fine, it is easy to say, “I am not the body.” But when there is pain, exhaustion, or illness, identity quickly attaches to the body. At that moment the seeker needs gentleness. Do not call pain false. Do not suppress it. Do not cover it with spiritual words. Pain is there, and it must be known. See: “Pain is in this part of the body. The body is uncomfortable. The mind is creating a story around pain. Fear may arise. Worry may arise. All this is being known.” Then say gently: “This is a state of the body. This is not my final nature. Neti.”

Neti is not a trick to remove pain. It clears identity. Pain may remain, treatment may continue, rest may be needed. But a clarity can arise: pain is in experience; I am not merely pain. This loosens identification with the body.

Now see the mind. The mind is a flow of thoughts, memories, desires, fears, imagination, and plans. It moves quickly into past, future, repetition, fantasy, fear, decision, and confusion. The mind feels so close that the seeker believes, “My thoughts are me.” But thoughts come and go. The thought of morning is different from afternoon, different from evening. Old beliefs have changed. Old fears have changed. Did “I” change with every thought?

Neti-Neti says: “This is a thought. This is a movement of mind. It is being known. It is not my final nature.” There is no need to stop the thought. See it. If the mind says, “I am a failure,” see: this is a thought. If the mind says, “I need respect,” see: this is thought and desire. If the mind says, “Everything will go wrong,” see: this is imagination of the future. Gently say: “Not this too. Neti.”

Neti applied to mind does not mean forcefully stopping thoughts. Thoughts are the nature of mind. The problem is not thought. The problem is identity with thought. A thought arises, "I am afraid." Identity says, "I am fear." Neti sees the thought and makes identity light.

Now look at emotions. Emotions feel deeper than thoughts because they are felt in the body. Fear tightens the body. Anger brings heat. Sorrow brings heaviness. Love brings softness. Joy brings lightness. When emotion rises, the seeker quickly says, "I am sad," "I am angry," "I am afraid," or "I am happy."

Do not deny emotion. If sorrow is arising, it is there. If fear is arising, it is there. If anger is arising, it is there. Respect it; do not suppress it. But see it. Emotion comes, remains, changes form, decreases, and leaves. Whatever comes and goes cannot be the final "I." Therefore emotion is also seen through Neti: sorrow is being experienced - Neti; fear is arising - Neti; a wave of anger is here - Neti; joy too is an experience - Neti.

When emotion arises, give it space. Name it: sorrow is here, fear is here, anger is here. Then notice where it is felt - chest, stomach, throat, breath. Then see what story the mind is adding. Sorrow may say, "This always happens to me." Fear may say, "Everything will fall apart." Now apply Neti gently. The emotion is known, the body sensation is known, the story is known.

The seeker often applies Neti to pain but forgets to apply it to pleasure. Sorrow comes and he says, "This is not me." Joy comes and he grasps it: "This is me." This too is identity. Happiness, love, peace, and joy are beautiful. Do not reject them. But do not grasp them. If peace came, it was known. If joy came, it was known. Neti with pain loosens identification. Neti with pleasure loosens grasping.

Neti must carry compassion. When the body is ill, do not become harsh. When the mind is confused, do not blame yourself. When emotion is intense, do not rush to remove it. Let the tone be loving: "Yes, this is experience. See it.

Do not get lost in it.” Without compassion, Neti becomes dry. With compassion, Neti becomes healing.

Practice for Today

Three times today, pause and ask: What is happening in the body right now? What thought or story is moving in the mind? What emotion is present? After each, say: “This is being known. This is not my final nature. Neti.” If there is pain, bring compassion. If the mind is confused, bring patience. If emotion is heavy, give it space.

Third Section - Neti Applied to Role, Story, and Spiritual Identity

In the previous section we applied Neti to body, mind, and emotion. Now we enter subtler layers: role, story, image, and spiritual identity. These identities are so normal that the seeker may not notice them.

Someone says, “I am a father.” Someone says, “I am a mother.” Someone says, “I am a teacher.” Someone says, “I am a servant.” Someone says, “I am a seeker.” Someone says, “My life story has been difficult.” Someone says, “I have understood.” None of these is wrong in its place. In practical life there are roles; in life there are stories; in society there is image; in sadhana there are experiences. But when any of these becomes the final “I,” the grip of ego returns.

Roles are necessary. Role shows responsibility. Neti does not erase role. It only prevents role from becoming final identity. Role says, “This is my function.” Ego says, “This is who I am.” If the father-role is present, play it with love and clarity. But if hardness arises - “My word must always be obeyed because I am

father” - role is becoming identity. If the teacher-role cannot hear a question, role has joined ego. If the seeker-role says, “I am deeper than ordinary people,” it has become spiritual identity. Bring Neti gently: “This role is known. It is not my final nature.”

A person changes roles many times in a day - parent, worker, friend, child, student, teacher. Roles change, but the basic sense “I am” remains. If role were the final “I,” the “I” would change with every role. But role changes and knowing remains.

Image is how I appear in the eyes of others. Let people see me as good, spiritual, successful, sensitive, strong, special. Image has a practical place, but to take image as final “I” is bondage. When image is hurt, the experiencer says, “What will people think?” “My respect will be lost.” “My spiritual image will break.” Image is a perception in other minds. It changes. What forms and dissolves in another mind cannot be my final nature. Neti says: concern for image is known; it is not me.

Every person carries a life-story: “This happened to me,” “I struggled,” “No one understood me,” “I built everything myself,” “I am different,” “I am broken,” “I am strong.” Some events may be true. Wounds may be real. Neti does not call the story false. It only asks: are you the story? Story lives in memory. The same event can be told as sorrow, pride, complaint, or specialness. The seeker sees: “The mind is telling an old story.” Then gently: “Neti. This story is not my final nature.”

One layer is the victim-story: “Wrong always happened to me,” “No one loved me,” “People used me.” Hurt must be seen and compassion is needed. But pain as permanent identity becomes bondage. The wound is seen, but the seeker does not become the wound. Another layer is the special-story: “I am different,” “My practice is unique,” “My experience is great.” This may give pleasure, but also creates separation. Neti sees the desire to be special and makes it light.

The subtlest field is spiritual identity. Sadhana, knowledge, experience, service, humility, and awareness can all be grasped by ego. So Neti must be applied here too: “I am a seeker” - Neti. “I am wise” - Neti. “I had an experience” - Neti. “I am in the witness” - Neti. “I am awake” - Neti. This does not mean abandoning practice. Practice continues, understanding is honored, service happens with love. But none of these becomes final identity.

Even “I am the witness” is a pointer, not a final object. If the mind turns it into a new spiritual ego, that thought too must be seen. The witness is not a role, image, or achievement. It is the quiet knowing presence in which all these are known.

When Neti deepens into role, image, story, and spiritual identity, natural humility arises. The seeker sees how many layers were being called “I.” The grip loosens. He can listen more, see more, admit mistakes, and walk his path without making others small.

Practice for Today

Today notice one role, story, or image. Maybe you felt identified as parent, guide, seeker, friend, or student. Maybe an old story arose. Ask: What identity is this? Does it change? Is it being known? Then gently say: “Not this too. Neti.” Let it be loving clarity.

Fourth Section - What Remains After Neti?

In the previous section we applied Neti to subtle identities. There is role, but I am not the role. There is image, but I am not the image. There is story, but I am not the story. There is spiritual experience, but I am not the experience. “I am a seeker,” “I am wise,” “I am special,” “I am wounded” - these too are

known identities. Now the question arises: if I am not body, mind, emotion, role, story, image, or spiritual identity, then what am I?

This question may create fear. Until now, the “I” seemed to be made of these things. One by one they are being seen. So the mind asks, “What remains?” Here Neti-Neti begins to reveal its secret. Neti is not meant to empty you into nothingness. It is not meant to erase you. It removes false identity so that what was always present may become clear.

When you say, “I am not the body,” do you disappear? No. The body is known. When you say, “I am not the mind,” do you end? No. The mind is known. When you say, “I am not the emotion,” does knowing stop? No. The emotion is known. When you say, “I am not the story,” someone still knows the story. So after Neti, blankness does not remain. Knowing becomes clearer. What falls away is false identity. What remains is the quiet knowing presence. In this course, we call it the witness.

Neti repeatedly brings us back toward the witness. Body seen - I am not the body. Mind seen - I am not the mind. Emotion seen - I am not the emotion. Role seen - I am not the role. Story seen - I am not the story. Spiritual experience seen - I am not the experience. Attention then turns toward that which knows all this. The seeker may say, “I am the witness.” This is useful as a pointer. Yet the witness is not a new role, thought, title, or achievement.

The mind asks, “What remains after Neti?” It waits for an object: light, peace, silence, bliss, a special state. But whatever remains as an experience is also known. Deep peace came - it was known. Joy came - it was known. Emptiness came - it was known. Silence came - it was known. What is known cannot be the final knower.

Through Neti, a different silence may open. This is not only absence of sound. It is the silence of loosened grasping. Earlier the mind immediately said, “I,” “mine,” “I want,” “I do not want.” Now this grip slows down. Experience is present in the body, but it does not instantly become “me.” A thought arises,

but belief is not immediate. An emotion comes, but identity does not form instantly. A space opens. This may feel like silence. But do not grasp even this silence. A silence that comes and goes is also experience.

Neti does not teach escape from the world. “I am not the body” does not mean neglect the body. “I am not the mind” does not mean become insensitive. “I am not the role” does not mean abandon responsibility. “I am not the story” does not mean stop learning from life. Neti gives life its proper place. The body is cared for, work is done, relationships are lived, emotions are given space, practice continues - but final identity is not made from any of these.

The fruit of Neti appears in life. Criticism may hurt, but the seeker can see, “Image has been touched - Neti.” Praise may bring joy, but he can see, “Recognition is being enjoyed - Neti.” The body may be tired, and rest is needed, but clarity remains: “Tiredness is in the body - Neti.” Worry may arise, but it is seen as a thought. Spiritual pride may arise, and the seeker can smile: “This too is a layer - Neti.”

How long must Neti continue? As long as identity attaches to changing things, Neti is useful. But Neti is not a mechanical mantra. It is the art of seeing. Gradually, the seeing itself becomes Neti. The seeker sees: this is changing; this is not my final nature; and returns to the quiet knowing presence.

This chapter’s essence is simple. Neti-Neti does not reject life. It loosens false identity. It is the gentle art of returning to the witness. The next chapter will move toward Mahavakya - the great statements that directly point toward the truth. Neti said, “not this.” Mahavakya will ask: then what?

Dear seeker, keep Neti-Neti gentle. Do not make it harsh. Do not use it to escape life. When identity forms with body, mind, emotion, role, story, or spiritual experience, see it - Neti. Then become quiet. What you are not will slowly loosen. What you are does not need to be manufactured. The sun does not practice becoming light. When clouds part, light is seen. Neti recognizes the clouds; it does not create the sun.

Practice for This Week

For the next seven days, keep Neti-Neti as a gentle practice. Whenever a strong identity arises, ask: Is this body or mind? Is this emotion or story? Is this role or image? Is this spiritual experience or spiritual ego? Then say: “This is being known. This is changing. This is not my final nature. Neti.” Then remain quiet for a few moments. Do not wait for light, bliss, or a special state. Simply see that experiences come and go, and the knowing is already here.